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« When everyone asks me about Indian football, I tell them the ISL is the image of Indian football, but it's the last part of the chain »

MANOLO MARQUEZ

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Five years ago, Manolo Marquez came to India from Barcelona during the first wave of the coronavirus pandemic to take on the Indian Super League (ISL) challenge.

He recalls the 'chaos' at Mumbai airport back then, which shocked him, but after five successful seasons filled with more highs than lows, the Spaniard now feels at home.

In August, Marquez also embarked on the difficult task of coaching the senior national team following Igor Stimac's exit. He will juggle both his FC Goa and India team duties until the end of the 2024-25 season.

While talking to *Sportstar* about

his five years in India, he highlighted the quality of the ISL, the challenges of his dual role, and more.

This is your fifth season in the ISL. Is this season shaping up to be the most competitive yet?

Yes, in terms of excitement, because all teams are very equal. In my previous four seasons, some teams always won. Obviously, Mohun Bagan and Mumbai are the top two teams. But in terms of competitiveness, yes, it is. However, those who follow the game will find it hard to agree on the quality, which, I think, was better in previous seasons.

Why do you think the quality has dropped?

I feel that the foreigners were better in the previous seasons. When you train with better players, your level increases, and you improve a lot. You can also improve if the league is very competitive. I think the level of some coaches [this year] is very high, very good. On that note, you could say it's very competitive, but on the other hand, I think the quality of the foreigners could be better.

Did you ever imagine staying this long when you first came to Goa in 2020, entering a bio-bubble, and now becoming the national team manager?

Sometimes I joke about this because I remember my first flight from Barcelona, reaching Mumbai, and the chaos at the airport — it was